

# Patanjali, the *Yoga Sutra*, and Indian Philosophy

---

## CHAPTER 2

At this point, it is necessary to introduce a small number of more or less untranslatable terms, foreign concepts, and names of philosophers and philosophical schools that will reappear throughout the rest of this book: a cast of *Yoga Sutra* characters and concepts. Nonspecialist readers not interested in the arcana of Sanskrit terminology may want to skip over much of this chapter.

The classical Indian commentators viewed the *Yoga Sutra* as a philosophical work, an investigation into the relationship between Spirit and Matter; an account of the workings of the mind and ways of knowing what is true; a study of cause and effect in the workings of the universe; and a guide to salvation. As is the case with every major Indian philosophical school and religious system, these fields of inquiry—ontology (the nature of being), epistemology (what it means to know), psychology (the workings of the mind), cosmology (the shape of the universe), and soteriology (being saved)—

are intertwined. While India has known many, many philosophical schools or systems (darshanas) over the past three millennia, the following six have been singled out, since the sixteenth century, as the “classical” Hindu darshanas: these are Samkhya, Yoga, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, and Vedanta. The first five of these can be dated back to the last centuries before the Common Era. Three among them—Nyaya (“Logic”), Vaisheshika (“Atomism”), and Mimamsa (“Vedic Exegesis”)—are largely irrelevant to the history of the *Yoga Sutra* and its history of interpretation. Samkhya (“Enumeration”), the system with which Yoga philosophy has the most in common, is of great importance. The last, known as Vedanta—because it based itself on the philosophy of the Upanishads, the final collection of teachings within the Vedic canon, which were also known as the “Veda’s end” (veda-anta)—emerged several centuries later. While there are three subschools of Vedanta philosophy—Dualist, Nondualist, and Qualified Nondualist—the Nondualist (Advaita) school that the great eighth- to ninth-century Shankaracharya (or Shankara) championed has been by far the most influential in the history of Hindu thought, especially over the past five hundred years. These Hindu systems did not develop in a vacuum however: two other philosophical systems that influenced, and were influenced by, Yoga philosophy were those of early Jainism and Buddhism.

Generally, one wants to begin at the beginning, but as is so often the case with ancient Indian traditions,

beginnings can be rather tricky. The *Yoga Sutra* is probably not the first Indian work to be devoted to either yoga or Yoga, although Indian texts are notoriously difficult to date. Generally speaking, Hindu scriptures are broadly divided into Revelation (shruti, literally “that which was heard”) and Tradition (smriti, literally “that which was recalled”). The former category covers the Vedas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads, Dharma-sutras, and the ritual Sutras, works considered to have been orally revealed to the ancient seers. Generally speaking, these works of Revelation date from between 1500 BCE and 400 CE. The latter category comprises India’s two great epics, the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*; the law books (called Smritis); and the Puranas and other sectarian works called the Tantras and Agamas.

The earliest extant works on Yoga philosophy fall on the cusp between these two bodies of scripture. Yoga and Samkhya are discussed at some length in the *Katha Upanishad*, a work of Revelation that likely dates from some time between 300 and 100 BCE. † Yoga is also the principal focus of the sixth book of another Upanishad, the *Maitri*, which may date from as late as or later than the *Yoga Sutra*. † The *Mahabharata* contains extended discussions of yoga and Yoga in its sixth and twelfth books, both of which are also more or less coeval with the *Yoga Sutra*. Some of the epic’s earlier books evoke a lost yoga tradition that glorified † the apotheosis of the dying chariot warrior and his embodied rise up to the world of the gods: in its descrip-

tions of these heroic deaths, the epic used the word “yoga” to denote the heavenly chariot that carried the warrior up through the orb of the sun to the elevated plane of the divine.

The portion of the *Mahabharata*’s sixth book in which Yoga is a prime focus is best known under the name of the *Bhagavad Gita*, which comprises a series of teachings on human responsibility, love of God, and the “three yogas” of action, knowledge, and devotion as revealed by the supreme god Krishna to the epic warrior Arjuna. This work would become the foundation of yoga as practiced by the various Vishnu-worshipping (Vaishnava) traditions, whose many proponents inserted chapters on yoga and Yoga into the Vaishnava Puranas. Several chapters of the *Mahabharata*’s twelfth book are also devoted to Yoga, to-

† together with Samkhya. In one of these, a divine figure named Hiranyagarbha (“Golden Embryo”) is identified as both a creator god and the primordial revealer of the Yoga system. Certain commentators provide a title for his teachings: *Hiranyagarbhayoga-shastra* (“Golden Embryo’s Treatise on Yoga”); and  
† several sources quote or cite his work, one of them quite extensively. Several Puranas would also identify Hiranyagarbha, rather than Patanjali, as the original revealer of Yoga. However, the bulk of the twelfth book’s extensive teachings on Samkhya and Yoga are attributed to Yajnavalkya, an ancient seer with an Upanishadic pedigree. Like Hiranyagarbha, Yajnavalkya is also identified as the author of a number

of later works on yoga and Yoga. As we will see shortly, the Puranas would entirely ignore Patanjali in favor of these and other mythic Yoga seers.

The *Mahabharata*'s twelfth book also mentions an early group of Shiva-worshipping (Shaiva) ascetics called the Pashupatas, who developed their own form of yoga, called Pashupata Yoga, during the same period. This alternate form of yoga—which persisted alongside Patanjali's Yoga, Tantric Yoga, and Hatha Yoga—is described in detail in the Shaiva Puranas as well as in an Indonesian work titled the *Dharma Patanjala*. We will return to these traditions in chapters 7 and 9. †

Like the earlier *Katha Upanishad*, the *Mahabharata* presents Yoga and Samkhya together. This is a commonplace of Yoga philosophy: that Yoga is but a variation on Samkhya philosophy, a program of meditation and other techniques erected upon a foundation of Samkhya metaphysics. If only for this reason, most *Yoga Sutra* manuscripts, in their colophons—the “credits” appended to manuscripts in which dates, authors' and commentators' names, and other information are provided—identify the work as an “interpretation of Samkhya” (samkhya-pravachana). From the twelfth century onward, authors would also refer to Patanjali's system as “Samkhya with Ishvara” (seshvara samkhya), by way of saying that the Yoga system's sole significant divergence from Samkhya theory concerned “Ishvara.” This critical term, which may be translated as “Lord,” “Master,” or “God,” will be discussed in chapter 10. †

Now, if Yoga philosophy were originally grounded in Samkhya, then one would expect to find a foundational work on Samkhya predating the *Yoga Sutra*. This is not the case: the earliest comprehensive work on Samkhya, the *Samkhya Karika* of Ishvara Krishna, is thought to date from the same period as the *Yoga Sutra*. Furthermore, as Peter Schreiner argued in a groundbreaking article, the *Mahabharata*'s presentation of Samkhya appears to presuppose a preexisting Yoga tradition rather than the other way around. Other sources, however, indicate that Samkhya came first. Most importantly, several traditions concur that a legendary sage named Kapila and his illustrious pupils systematized Samkhya several centuries before the beginning of the Common Era. The names of these sages are also found in the *Mahabharata*.

At bottom, the relationship between Samkhya and Yoga—if indeed the two strands were ever separate from each other—is a chicken and egg question. What we do know is that the centuries prior to the beginning of the Common Era saw the emergence of nearly all of the great Indian philosophical systems, systems of remarkable sophistication and complexity: Jainism, Buddhism, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, Yoga, and Samkhya. Here, it is essential to understand that in spite of their marked disagreements over issues of ontology, soteriology, and so forth, the proponents of these schools—the authors of their foundational texts and commentaries—all agreed on a great many matters. Not the least of these was that a philosophical sys-

tem had to be coherent and rigorous at every level. These philosophical systems were unified Theories of Everything, and because everything in the universe is interconnected, everything—knowing, being, being saved, cause and effect, time, space, mind, body, etc. etc.—had to be consistent. In this respect theirs were very much like the current Theory of Everything of modern-day theoretical physics, whose models for the origin of the universe, the fabric of space-time, the relationship between matter and energy, and so forth cannot allow for the slightest flaw or internal contradiction. Otherwise, the perfect mathematical crystal collapses.

Like modern-day theoretical physicists, the ancient commentators were members of an intellectual elite, writing for one another and not for the unwashed masses. They and their philosophical systems, did, however, differ from those of modern theoretical physics on two critical points. The first, and most obvious, is that their motive behind decrypting the workings of the universe was a soteriological one, carried out in the name of freeing humans from the prison of suffering existence. This was an agenda set in the middle of the first millennium BCE, in both the Hindu Upanishads and the foundational scriptures of Buddhism and Jainism, the two highly ascetic “new” religions of ancient India. Because of their soteriological focus, these schools generated a vision of the universe, which, while entirely different from our own, was nonetheless rational, coherent, and verifiable on the basis of

their foundational axioms. By the time of the *Yoga Sutra*, all of human knowledge had been organized around this goal, such that each of the leading philosophical systems was able to fully explain and link together all known physical and spiritual phenomena, including reincarnation, memories of past lives, cause and effect, “supernatural” powers, and so forth into a unified whole.

Because, however, their explanations for the unseen forces underlying the visible universe do not correspond to those of modern science, we moderns refer to their systems as metaphysics, as opposed to the mathematically provable laws of physics. This brings us to the second major point of difference between the ancient Indian philosophers and modern-day theoretical physicists. The latter use mathematics, a universal notation system whose signifiers—numbers, equations, algorithms, and so forth—remain constant and transparently equivalent to that which they signify, no matter where or when that language is being written or read. Not so for the Indian philosophers, whose language of expression was Sanskrit, a “perfected” (this is the meaning of the word) language to be sure, but a far less precise mode of expression than the language of mathematics. This is what made commentaries so vitally necessary: in order to demonstrate that the axioms of a given philosophical system were valid, the technical language of those axioms had to be analyzed in hair-splitting detail. For this reason, commentators

† were also attentive to Indian theories of language, of

the power of words to represent reality—or even to (re)create reality, as in the case of the Vedic mantras. Nonetheless, this language-based format has made ancient Indian philosophy terribly fragile, protean, and difficult to grasp for modern-day interpreters. As we saw for the simple definition of Yoga in the last chapter, the translation of terms whose meanings have changed over time is a daunting task. This is also why I compared the work of commentators and scholars to the practice of judicial review in the American legal system. Metaphysical positions that were set forth in words rather than mathematical formulas are more like legal precedents than the postulates of theoretical physics.

With this, let us dwell for a moment on some of the basic principles of ancient Samkhya-Yoga philosophy, which form the context for the bulk of the *Yoga Sutra*'s aphorisms, as well as their commentaries. To begin, this is a Dualist system, comprised of Spirit and Matter. While there are many individual Persons or Spirits, Nature or Matter—which comprises all of the stuff of the universe, including every human body *and every human mind*—is one. Although it is unified, our universe, the stuff of Prakriti, is in constant flux, morphing into a series of twenty-four unstable entities, principles, or substrates, called tattvas. Some of those are more stable than others, and the citta—which, because it is part of matter, is often translated as “mind-stuff”—pulled and stretched in every direction by the senses, is constantly organizing these into

“me” (ego, ahamkara), other people, animals, houses, and all the other things in the world. Utterly separate from these is Purusha, the twenty-fifth principle.

Why is all of Nature constantly in flux? It is here that we may see how Samkhya-Yoga, like every other Indian philosophy, functions in the service of salvation, of freeing humans from suffering existence. The goal here is to free the mind from its misconception that the Person or Spirit is trapped in the cycle of death and rebirth. Although all the Persons in the universe are embedded in Matter, they are not subject to its laws: each Person is pure, luminous, transcendent consciousness. Yet it is precisely when it comes into contact or proximity with a Person (also called a “Viewer” or “Spectator” [drastr])—that Nature (also called “What is Seen” [drsya]) is set into motion, evolving and devolving into the various substrates of the phenomenal world, putting on a spectacle for the Spectator to see. Even though Nature, *including the mind-stuff*, is entirely unconscious—with its mutations occurring like the behavior of iron filings around a magnet—the great Shankara’s description of Nature as an actress or a dancer is one that many a philosopher has evoked down through the centuries. Even as Nature in its many permutations is unconscious, its “performance” serves a purpose: to stimulate each Person, each “Spectator,” to realize that it is not a part of the spectacle it has been watching, that is, to realize its intrinsic “isolation” (kaivalyam) from Her. When this is accomplished, She leaves the stage.

The role of the substrate that Patanjali calls the mind-stuff is absolutely critical here, because it is not only the most immediate interface between the individual Person and the rest of the universe, but also the most volatile. The mind-stuff is the mirror in which the luminous “Spectator” sees itself, but that mirror is a funhouse mirror made of the same stuff as the Terminator in “Terminator Two,” altering its shape, form, size, and quality at every moment. Its flux is the result of the mind’s ever-changing reactions to sensory stimuli, erroneous conceptions, passions, emotions, memories (both immediate and of past lives), and so forth. These are the “turnings of thought” or “fluctuations of the mind-stuff” (*citta-vritti*) of the *Yoga Sutra*’s definition of Yoga, which the commentator Vachaspati Mishra interpreted as “mutation into the form of an object.” While the form that that mental flux will most often take is that of the transient, death-laden body with which it identifies (by positing an ego), its potential forms, qualities, and extensions are limitless. So it is that when the mind-stuff is drawn away from the body and the senses and toward the pure luminous consciousness of the Person, it seemingly becomes conscious, while in fact it is simply absorbing and reflecting the Person’s own mode of being. †

In the Samkhya system, the Person’s gradual realization of its freedom from the material world, death and rebirth is effected through rational inquiry into each of the substrates through which Nature devolves, all the way down to gross matter, the inert stuff of the

body and the universe. These include the five elements, the senses, mind, and ego, culminating in the intellect (buddhi). By fully knowing them, the Samkhya philosopher gradually comes to realize that the Person has no part in them. In Yoga, the method of practice changes to one of concentration, meditation, and introspection, issuing into a direct yogic perception (yogi-pratyaksha) of what truly is, a type of knowledge that is entirely intuitive and nonconceptual, bypassing the “turnings of thought” entirely. At the outset, this involves restraining the activities of the body, followed by breath control, because by stilling the breaths one quiets the senses and stabilizes the mind. Then, through deepening stages of meditation, the practitioner’s thinking process or mind-stuff is trained away from the outward stimuli that normally render it so unstable and bound to the lower substrates of Matter, and then toward concentration on the luminous, immobile Person itself. Because the mind-stuff absorbs and reflects the qualities of its increasingly subtle objects, it too becomes increasingly subtle, stable, and expansive. When perfect concentration (samadhi) is achieved, the mind-stuff becomes pure, tranquil, and transparent to pure consciousness, expanding out to the farthest reaches of space to disappear from view. With this, Nature has left the stage, and with nothing left to view, her Spectator, no longer subject to the filtering or distorting effects of the mind-stuff, becomes aware of His isolation from the activities of the material world, and “dwells in His own form.”

lation from the flux of suffering existence has been realized, suffering ceases.

Yoga philosophy postulates that the mind-stuff, or more properly speaking, Nature's highest evolute, the intellect, has the power to penetrate anywhere and expand infinitely. This was a subject of sustained discussion in the classical commentarial tradition, and its implications continue to resonate in scholarly circles down to the present day. Here it is essential to note an important distinction between classical Indian and modern Western theories of perception. In the Indian case, the "thinking principle or intellect assumes the form of the object perceived . . . when it is active and influenced by external objects it assumes the forms of its excitants."<sup>1</sup> The same logically applies to the dimensions of the perceived object, such that when the thinking principle or intellect is observing the outermost and most subtle reaches of the universe, it is simultaneously stretched out to universal dimensions. This principle, already introduced in the *Mahabharata*, is carried forward in a wide variety of works on Yoga. The implication here is that a yogi's body attains universal dimensions as well: this is one of the supernatural powers of the yogi alluded to in the *Yoga Sutra's* third chapter.

Once it has been trained through the practice of yogic meditation, the mind-stuff's limitless potential for expansion sets the stage for what are often referred to as the "supernatural powers," the main topic of the *Yoga Sutra's* third chapter. These include the mind-

- † stuff's power to enter into the bodies of other beings,
- † the power of flight, invisibility, the ability to read other people's minds, to know one's past and future lives, and knowledge of what is subtle, hidden, and distant. Colophons refer to this as the chapter on *vibhuti*, a word that literally means "the power to extend everywhere." When understood in the context of Samkhya-
- † Yoga metaphysics, there is nothing supernatural about these powers. As the mind-stuff absorbs and reflects the Person's luminous power of consciousness, it, like
- † consciousness, becomes omnipresent, capable of penetrating or transforming into anything, and cognizant of everything. We will return to the place of these powers in chapter 7.

While all of the major Indian philosophical systems have salvation as their goal, and while most agree that the workings of the mind are both the source and the potential solution to the problem of suffering, they take radically different positions on several essential points. Because we will be returning to it frequently in these pages, one of these—the relationship of the Person (Purusha), or Self (Atman, Brahman) to the material world—must be addressed here. As we have seen, in the Dualist system of Samkhya-Yoga, *both individual Persons (Purushas) and the Matter in which they are embedded are real*, but they are radically separate. Here, the goal of practice is to realize their separateness and thereby free the Person from its imagined entanglements with the material world. In distinction to this, the Nondualist system of Advaita Vedanta main-

tains that *the universal Self (Brahman) is real but that the material world is unreal*. There is nothing that exists that is not the Self; however, due to “cosmic illusion” (maya), individual selves believe that they are distinct entities, cut off from one another and the universal Self by illusory bodies and the stuff of the world. Here the goal of practice is to realize that all that is not Brahman is an illusion. By truly knowing that all is one and internal to Brahman, the individual self achieves identity with the universal Self, even though in reality it never was truly distinct from it. Finally, according to the Buddha’s teachings, *both the individual self and the material world are unreal*, and there is no transcendent Self. There is only suffering, which the “no-self” (anatta) identifies with, due to the wanderings of the mind, which chases after chimerical objects that are its own projections.

This is all heady stuff, ample witness to the fact that the worldview of Patanjali and his classical commentators was very different from our own. For all this, the highly technical philosophical passages of these works are often interspersed with allusions to real-world phenomena that are far more familiar. We have already noted Shankara’s comparison of Prakriti to an actress or dancer who puts on a show for Purusha, her passive Spectator. So, too, the metaphor of a magnet and iron filings to evoke the effect of conscious Spirit on unconscious Matter is one that does not give us brain cramps. Some images are quite lovely: the reflection of a flower

† in a glass, water sliding through the sluice gate of an irrigation channel, bees following their queen, a humble wooden cart carrying a precious, fragrant load of saffron. Notably absent from the *Yoga Sutra* and its commentaries is the slightest reference to a yogic “lifestyle,” of living in harmony with nature in a forest existence or remote monastery, hermitage, or cave.

† The place where one would expect to find such references is the most straightforward and user-friendly portion of the *Yoga Sutra*, the second of its four chapters (*padas*), which is devoted to practice. Here, two types of practice are proposed. For the nonspecialist, there is “practical yoga” (*kriya yoga*), which has three parts: asceticism, the study and recitation of sacred hymns and syllables, and dedication to Ishvara. For the practitioner questing for liberation from suffering existence, Patanjali introduces the eight-part practice, which comprises the (1) inner and (2) outer restraints, (3) posture, (4) breath control, (5) retraction of the senses, (6) fixation, (7) meditation, and (8) pure contemplation. Comprising the final twenty-eight verses of chapter 2 and the three opening verses of chapter 3, Patanjali’s presentation of the eight-part practice is a short respite from the highly theoretical focus of the greater bulk of his work. A compact step-by-step approach to the practice of meditation, it receives limited attention from the classical commentators. There are two possible explanations for this general commentarial disregard for practice. The first is that the commen-

tators did not meditate or practice yoga. The second is that although they may have undertaken the eight-part practice in their private lives, their public roles as commentators obliged them to stay on message and to focus on the *Yoga Sutra* as a Theory of Everything.

Standing (or sitting in lotus posture) at the opposite end of the spectrum are the modern-day yoga gurus, who, in their frequent references to the *Yoga Sutra*, rarely refer to any but the thirty-one verses that comprise Patanjali's teaching on the eight-part practice. In so doing they often confuse the part for the whole, presenting the eight-part practice as the "essence" of Yoga, to the exclusion of the work's other 164 verses. The same yoga gurus, as well as some critical Yoga scholars, also tend to assume that Patanjali personally practiced the Yoga described in the *Yoga Sutra*, that he was something more than an intellectual author of a Theory of Everything.

The issue of the historical Patanjali and his relationship to the work attributed to him brings us back to the question of origins. As I have already noted, several yogas were in vogue prior to the composition of the *Yoga Sutra*, and some of these involved meditation. In addition, there were several meditation traditions—those of the Jains and Buddhists in particular—that while they did not call themselves "yoga" certainly anticipated many of the concepts and practices found in Patanjali's work. So it is that some classical commentators and most critical scholars have viewed Patanjali not as an original author, but rather as a compiler who

† wove together at least two—but perhaps as many as six—preexisting Yoga traditions or texts.

King Bhoja, an important eleventh-century commentator, was the first to concern himself—primarily for purposes of self-promotion—with the identity, or multiple identities, of Patanjali. “Patanjali” is listed as the name of one of the twenty-six mythical Divine Serpents in a number of Puranas. One of these was the sixth-century *Vishnudharmottara Purana*, a work from Kashmir, where Patanjali has long been particularly revered. According to the *Vishnudharmottara*, “the image of Patanjali’s Yoga teaching should have the form of Ananta,” Ananta being the name of the divine Lord of Serpents who bears the entire universe upon his thousand outspread cobra hoods. This was noted by Bhoja, who went on to write the following verses of (self-) praise in the introduction to his “Royal Sun” commentary:

† I bow with folded hands to Patanjali, the best of sages, who removed the impurities of the mind through yoga; the impurities of speech through grammar; and the impurities of the body through medicine. To he whose upper body has a human form, who holds a conch and a wheel, who is white and has a thousand heads, to that Patanjali, I offer obeisance. Victory be to the luminous words of the illustrious sovereign [Bhoja] . . . who by creating his grammar, by writing his comment on the Patanjalian [treatise, the *Yoga Sutra*], and by producing

[a work] on medicine . . . has—like the Lord of the Protectors of Serpents—removed defilement from our speech and minds and bodies.<sup>2</sup>

This identification of a single figure named Patanjali as the author of foundational works in the three fields of philosophy, grammar, and medicine is not without historical precedent. While it is generally accepted that Patanjali was the author-compiler of a philosophical treatise, the *Yoga Sutra*, there also exist commentaries on two other works that were written by a figure having the same name. One of these is the *Mahabhashya*, the “Great Commentary” on Panini’s authoritative Sanskrit grammar, which dates from about the second century BCE. In it, the commentator Patanjali refers to himself as the son of a woman named Gonika, † a name that resurfaces in a twelfth-century myth. The other, a commentary on the *Charaka Samhita*, a foundational work on Ayurveda, likely dates to a century or two before Bhoja’s time. † This timeline makes it highly doubtful that these three Patanjalis could have been one and the same person. In more traditional circles, however, Bhoja’s identification has become an oft-repeated article of faith, and his glorification of the three-in-one Patanjali continues to be recited in B.K.S. † Iyengar Yoga classes around the world.

In the modern-day yoga subculture, the most widely circulated explanation for Patanjali’s link to the serpent world is, like so many Indian origin myths, based on an etymology—a linguistic breakdown—of Patan-

jali's name, which several grammarians derived from the Sanskrit words *patat* ("falling") and *anjali*, the reverentially "joined hands" one sees in the decor of seemingly every Indian restaurant on the planet: "falling into joined hands." In about the twelfth century, a pilgrim's guide to the great temple complex of Cidambaram, the "home of the dancing Shiva," in the south Indian state of Tamil Nadu, provided a narrative to explain this etymology. In the same century, several sculpted images of this half-serpent, half-human Patanjali were carved into the Cidambaram temple's walls; similar images are found in other Shaiva temples of south India. According to this pilgrim's guide, the Lord of Serpents sought rebirth as a human in order to witness Shiva's awesome dance at Cidambaram. When he emerged from her body in a half-human, half-serpent form, his human mother, shocked at the sight of her hybrid offspring, let him fall from her hand. So he was named Patancali, the Tamil equivalent of the Sanskrit Patanjali.

This narrative explanation for the images of Patanjali that a twelfth-century pilgrim would have seen at the Cidambaram temple nonetheless makes no link between the semiserpentine devotee Patanjali and the human author-commentator of the same name, and this in spite of the fact that one of the prayer books used there, the *Patanjali Puja Sutra*, is said by modern-day temple priests to have been composed by Patanjali the grammarian. Also absent from this myth is the identification of the serpent-boy Patanjali's mother as

Gonika. Those connections would not be made until †  
 the seventeenth century, in the south Indian poet  
 Ramabhadra Dikshita's *Patanjali Charita* ("Story of  
 Patanjali"). Then, in the eighteenth century, Mariton-  
 tadarya, a Shaiva master from the south Indian state of  
 Karnataka, would identify this mythic Patanjali with  
 the Yoga philosopher:

Out of grace to the world and by way of introduc- †  
 ing the sciences of yoga and so forth, [the] primal  
 [serpent named] Shesha [i.e., Ananta took] the  
 form of the seven-year-old son of a brahmin  
 woman named Gonika. [By virtue of] "falling into  
 her hand," he was named Patanjali.<sup>3</sup>

These late south Indian myths are evidence for a six-  
 teenth- to eighteenth-century "Yoga revival" in south  
 India, which, as we will see, may have motivated Iyen-  
 gar's guru, the great Tirumalai Krishnamacharya, to  
 study the *Yoga Sutra* in the twentieth century. Apart  
 from the twelfth-century Patanjali shrine at Cidam-  
 baram, there is no historical record of any temple ever †  
 having been dedicated to Patanjali prior to the 2004  
 inauguration of just such a shrine to the author of the  
*Yoga Sutra* by Iyengar in Bellur (Karnataka), the city of  
 his birth. No doubt inspired by Maritontadarya,  
 whose work was published in Hubli, a few hundred  
 miles to the north, in 1936, Iyengar further embel-  
 lished the story of the serpent-boy Patanjali's birth  
 into the version known to the same pupils who recite

Bhoja's praise to the three-in-one Patanjali at the start of each of their Ashtanga Yoga classes. Iyengar's retelling takes Ananta-Shesha's witnessing of the dance of Shiva (without the mention of Cidambaram) as its starting point, after which:

- † Adisesa [i.e., Ananta] then began to meditate to ascertain who would be his mother on earth. In meditation, he had the vision of a yogini by the name of Gonika who was praying for a worthy son to whom she could impart her knowledge and wisdom. He at once realized that she would be a worthy mother for him, and awaited an auspicious moment to become her son. Gonika, thinking that her earthly life was approaching its end, and that her desire of finding a worthy son would remain unfulfilled; now, as a last resort looked to the Sun God, the living witness of God on earth and prayed to Him to fulfill her desire. She took a handful of water as a final oblation to Him, closed her eyes and meditated on the Sun. As she was about to offer the water, she opened her eyes and looked at her palms. To her surprise, she saw a tiny snake moving in her palms, who soon took on a human form. This tiny male human being prostrated to Gonika and asked her to accept him as her son. This she did and named him Patanjali. *Pata* means falling or fallen and *anjali*. . . means "hands folded in prayer." Gonika's prayer with folded hands thus bears the name Patanjali.<sup>4</sup>

Critical scholars dismiss all of this as mythology, of no value for excavating the historical Patanjali, the man who presumably walked the earth in the early centuries of the Common Era. For many Hindus, however, these myths are highly meaningful, since they lend a cachet of authenticity, if not divine intervention, to the production of our text. If, like Hiranyagarbha in the *Mahabharata*, Patanjali were a god who came down to earth to reveal a divine teaching to the world, then that teaching would count as Revelation (shruti), and as revelation it would have been transmitted orally down the ages, from guru to disciple, through rote recitation. Although there is no hard evidence to prove it, several scholars—as well as Iyengar, †  
Deshikachar, Prabhavananda, Isherwood, and others—believe that this was how the *Yoga Sutra* was traditionally transmitted. It may be that Vyasa also viewed the *Yoga Sutra* as belonging to the canon of revelation; however, for him, Patanjali would merely †  
have been the human transmitter of that revelation †  
and not its divine source.

While I will be referring to over a dozen classical *Yoga Sutra* commentators in this book, five stand out in terms of their antiquity and importance. Four of these have already been mentioned: Vyasa, Shankara, Vachaspati Mishra, and Bhoja. Here, some background on these men and their works, as well as on the fifth great *Yoga Sutra* commentator, Vijnanabhikshu, is in order. We have already begun to look at issues surrounding the relationship between Vyasa's "Commen-

tary” and the *Yoga Sutra*, with the majority scholarly opinion being that Vyasa was a near contemporary of Patanjali. A significant minority opinion, however, maintains that Vyasa lived several centuries later, and that his “Hindu-izing” commentary, rather than elucidating Patanjali’s text, actually subverted its original “Buddhist” teachings. I will return to this provocative hypothesis in the final chapter of this book.

Following Vyasa was another commentator whose identity has also been a source of disagreement among critical scholars. This is Shankara, whom some identify with Shankaracharya, the illustrious ninth-century Advaita Vedanta theologian, commentator, debater—and, according to legend, the founder of a confederation of brahmanic religious orders known as the *Dandins* or *Dasnamis*. An intellectual giant, Shankara wrote commentaries on several essential religious and philosophical works, including an early Upanishad, the *Bhagavad Gita*, the *Samkhya Karika*, and the *Brahma Sutra*. Many of the traditions surrounding Shankara are apocryphal, including, for some scholars, the claim that the Shankara authored a work titled the *Patanjalayogashastrabhaskhyavivarana* (“Exposition of the Commentary on the Yoga Teaching of Patanjali”). Like Patanjali, Shankara is a relatively common name, and so this too may have been a less illustrious Shankara. This is the position of several scholars, most notably T. S. Rukmani, for whom this commentary cannot date from before the fourteenth century. Central to their argument is the fact that the ninth-century

Shankaracharya flatly rejects the “stoppage of the turnings of thought” of *Yoga Sutra* 1.2 as a means to release from suffering existence. Trevor Leggett, the editor and translator of the “Exposition,” offers several counterarguments to this position. As Leggett notes, this commentator takes many of the same positions and uses much of the same philosophical terminology as those of the ninth-century figure who authored the commentary on the *Bhagavad Gita* and other works. This commentator’s argument *against* the Samkhya Dualism of the *Yoga Sutra* and Vyasa’s commentary is also typical of the great Shankara’s Advaita Vedanta position. Most importantly, his assertion that there is only one Purusha—and that that Purusha is God, Ishvara, who dwells in everything, but whose power of illusion is the cause of suffering for the ignorant—is Leggett’s proof that this was the work of the great ninth-century teacher. In effect, Shankara devotes the longest passages of his “Exposition” to demonstrating that Patanjali’s Ishvara is none other than the supreme being who created the universe and who is the object of Hindu devotion. †

The sole classical commentator capable of holding his own with Shankara in terms of erudition, debating skills, and originality was the circa 950 CE Vachaspati Mishra, whose given name speaks volumes on who and what he was: Vachaspati means “Talk-Meister.” The author of eight major works covering all of the major philosophical systems, Vachaspati Mishra was something of an intellectual diva, capable “of advocat- †

ing each of them even when their standpoints were at variance with one another.”<sup>5</sup> So it is that we see him

- † attacking the possibility of direct yogic perception in a commentary on Nyaya philosophy, and treating the same with complete seriousness in his commentary on the *Yoga Sutra*. That work, titled the *Tattvavaisharadi* (“Expert Guide to the True Principles”), is considered to be the most learned, balanced, and comprehensive of all *Yoga Sutra* commentaries. That being said, Vachaspati Mishra did not regard the *Yoga Sutra* to be the sole authority on Yoga philosophy. Quoting a work titled the *Yogi Yajnavalkyasmriti* (“Tradition of Yogi Yajnavalkya”), he inferred that Hiranyagarbha’s Yoga system may have preceded Patanjali’s. Elsewhere, in his commentary on the *Vedantasutras*, he expressed doubt that the axioms of Vedanta could ever challenge the authority of these two Yoga systems. As we will see, history proved him to be incorrect on this count.

- Vachaspati Mishra’s work was the main inspiration for King Bhoja’s eleventh-century *Rajamartandavritti* (“Royal Sun Commentary”), quoted above on the subject of the three-in-one Patanjali. Unlike every other major commentator on the *Yoga Sutra*, Bhoja wholeheartedly embraced Yoga philosophy, devoting the
- † final portion of his commentary to a Samkhya-Yoga refutation of every other school’s position on the nature of Purusha. We have already seen that Bhoja did not hesitate to compare himself to Patanjali in terms of commentarial prowess. In the final words of his commentary, he praises himself yet again, speaking of

other kings who are “prostrate at his feet in acts of service and salutation.” This may not have been an idle boast. The illustrious ruler of the kingdom of Malwa in west central India, he is one of the rare classical commentators about whom we have some biographical data. An enlightened despot, Bhoja was also a great military strategist who succeeded in driving back, if only for a time, Mahmud of Ghazni, the notorious Afghan invader who was the scourge of western India in the opening decades of the eleventh century. He was also an exemplary patron of the arts and the innovator of a massive public works project involving the damming of two rivers for the creation of the massive 250-square-mile Bhojpur Lake. †

The centuries separating Vachaspati Mishra and Bhoja were the *Yoga Sutra*’s glory days. This was the period during which Patanjali’s work was most widely quoted and enjoyed its greatest prestige, from Kashmir to Indonesia to Central Asia. But by the sixteenth century, the time of Vijñanabhikṣu, the *Yoga Sutra*’s last great commentator, things had changed. On the one hand, a new religio-philosophical paradigm had been forged between the theism of the Puranas and Vedānta philosophy. On the other, brahmin orthodoxy had, in the face of the onslaught of Islam in the northern part of the subcontinent, hardened with respect to all “non-Vedic” traditions, including Yoga. †

Vijñanabhikṣu was the author of two commentaries—the *Yogavarttika* (“Explanation of Yoga”) and the *Yogasarasamgraha* (“Short Statement on the Essence

of Yoga”). Like Shankara, Vijñanabhikṣu was a Vedānta philosopher; however, unlike Shankara, he was † not an Advaita Vedānta philosopher. Rather than taking a Nondualist stance, his was what has been termed “Qualified Nondualism” (Viśiṣṭadvaita). For Vijñanabhikṣu, this meant that while the union of each individual Puruṣa with the divine could be realized psychologically, the two would always remain separate on a metaphysical level, in the same way that Puruṣa and Prakṛti were always metaphysically separate.

Most important for the history of *Yoga Sūtra* commentary, however, was Vijñanabhikṣu’s position on Ishvara. While earlier commentators (with the exception of Shankara, if his “Exposition” had in fact been written in the ninth century) had refused to allow that Patañjali’s Ishvara could be construed as the divine creator of the universe, Vijñanabhikṣu saw matters differently. This is not to say that he was the originator of the ideas he was expounding: although he wrote as a philosopher (and perhaps a yoga practitioner, as Rukmani has maintained), he was also a man of his times, and by the sixteenth century the Hindu world had radically changed. In fact, it had been changing since the time of the *Bhagavad Gītā* and the Purāṇas, which defined Yoga not as the “stoppage of the turnings of thought,” but rather as union with God.

† About a dozen Purāṇas, dating from the fourth to fourteenth centuries, contain one or more chapters on Yoga. Not one of these gives a comprehensive account of the *Yoga Sūtra* or its philosophical system, and al-

though five Puranas provide long lists of yoga gurus and disciples, Patanjali's name is conspicuously absent from all of them. Instead, one finds in them the names of mainly Vedic and Upanishadic sages—but also those of Kapila, the legendary revealer of the Samkhya system, and Hiranyagarbha, whom the *Mahabharata* had identified as the founder of the Yoga system. Across all of the Puranas, only a handful of verses from the *Yoga Sutra* are quoted—and most of these inaccurately. Only five—the *Agni*, *Shiva*, *Linga*, *Kurma*, and *Markandeya*—provide even a paraphrase of the *Yoga Sutra*'s definition of Yoga. About half mention the eight-part practice, the others focusing instead on the six-part practice (shadangayoga) of the *Maitri Upanishad*, the “three yogas” of the *Bhagavad Gita*, as well as Pashupata Yoga, Hatha Yoga, Tantric Yoga, the healing properties of yoga, and so forth. As for the seven Puranas that do discuss the eight-part practice, none frame it within the context of Samkhya-Yoga philosophy, and only the *Shiva* acknowledges the *Yoga Shastra* (which may not be the same work as the *Yoga Sutra*) as its source. None respect the *Yoga Sutra*'s account of Ishvara, but rather speak of Yoga as union with a supreme creator god, identified with both the Brahman of Vedanta philosophy and either Vishnu, Shiva, or Devi, the three supreme deities of Hindu theism. † † † †

In reading these authoritative works on medieval Hinduism, one comes away with the impression that their authors were either unaware of the *Yoga Sutra* as an independent tradition, or that they were self-

consciously censoring Patanjali from their Puranic systems—which were, after all, grounded in the power of an omnipotent God to offer grace and salvation to all His (or Her) devotees. Indeed, this is the principal use the Puranas make of the eight-part practice: as a means to meditating on God in one’s own heart and realizing union with Him. Most critical Yoga scholars agree that the eight-part practice was a preexisting independent tradition that Patanjali adapted into his *Yoga Sutra*. While it cannot be known whether the *Mahabharata*’s teachings on Yoga were earlier or later than the *Yoga Sutra*, the fact is that the *Mahabharata*’s twelfth book does briefly mention the eight-part practice. This being the case, it is possible that the compilers of the Puranas—the earliest of which may have predated the *Yoga Sutra* but postdated the *Mahabharata*—were entirely unaware of Patanjali and his Dualist Samkhya-based Yoga system. As we will see in later chapters, virtually every modern-day yoga guru beginning with Swami Vivekananda has followed the lead of the Puranas, rather than that of the *Yoga Sutra*, in their interpretation of the eight-part practice. In other words, they have fundamentally misconstrued what they consider to be the very heart of Patanjali’s system.

Clearly influenced by the Puranic traditions, Vi-jnanabhikshu affirmed that even if the goal of Yoga practice were the isolation of the Person from Matter, this did not preclude the fact that beyond each individual spirit there was God, the supreme Self and the  
† creator of all, transcending all. For this reason, he

chose to view Ishvara as the twenty-sixth principle, higher even than the multiple Purushas identified as the twenty-fifth and highest principle in classical Samkhya. This assertion, already found in the *Mahabharata*'s twelfth book and several later works, is nowhere present in earlier *Yoga Sutra* commentary. †

Patanjali and Vyasa had presented Ishvara as an object of meditation, a means to the end of the stoppage of the turnings of thought and the ultimate goal of the isolation of the individual Person from universal Matter. In Vedanta philosophy and Puranic theism however, God became both the alpha and the omega of meditation: the practitioner, by meditating on Him (or Her) in his heart, realizes the innate and eternal identity of his individual self with the universal Self. A number of works betray the transition, from Samkhya Dualism to Vedanta Nondualism, and from the Ishvara of Patanjali's system to the universal Self of Vedanta. One of these was the *Agni Purana*, which fused † the two into a principle called Brahman-Ishvara, and identified samadhi as the individual soul's union with that principle. Another was the circa 1340 *Sarvadarshanasangraha* ("Compendium of All the Systems"), the last great philosophical work to truly defend Patanjali's system. Yet in doing so, its author, Sayana Madhava, a royal minister from the south Indian Vijayanagara kingdom, nonetheless betrayed the erosion of the position of the *Yoga Sutra* with respect to both Vedanta and other Yoga systems. Even as he championed what he termed the "Patanjali Darshana," rank-

ing it higher than all of the sixteen systems he surveyed with the exception of Vedanta, Madhava tailored Yoga philosophy to conform to Vedanta doctrines. So it is that while he supported Vyasa's emphatic reading of *Yoga Sutra* 1.2—that Yoga was to be defined as samadhi and *not* union—he nonetheless argued, from the precedent of a tenth- to twelfth-century south Indian work titled the *Yoga Yajnavalkya* ("Yajnavalkya's Yoga"), that

† the word samadhi itself could also be read to mean "union." In the same spirit of devotion that was the hallmark of medieval Hindu theism, but not of Patanjali's system, Madhava equated Ishvara with Krishna, whom he identified as the transcendent twenty-sixth

† principle. Elsewhere, he also introduced several elements of Tantric and Hatha Yoga into his account of Patanjali's system, including the use of specifically tantric mantras, discussions of yogic physiology, and techniques of breath control.

Vijñanabhikṣu had no compunctions about adding the supreme category of Ishvara to the standard

† Samkhyan system, because for him, the atheism of Samkhya was a "mere hyperbolic assertion," a "concession to current views," given the fact that by his time "Samkhya doctrine [had] been devoured by the sun of time and only a tiny crescent moon of [its form of] knowledge [was] still visible."<sup>6</sup> And so it was that by the sixteenth century, devotional Hinduism, which equated the universal Self of Vedanta philosophy with a personal God, had collapsed nearly every philosophical system into its perfect theological crystal. In a com-

plete reversal of Patanjali's and Vyasa's original positions, the Ishvara of the *Yoga Sutra* had come to be equated with the Krishna of the *Bhagavad Gita*. †

During the same period that it was being eclipsed by the theistic Yoga systems of the Puranas, the *Yoga Sutra* was being openly attacked on another front. Here I am speaking of commentators on the compendia of orthodox Hindu law known as the Smritis. Some of the Smritis date from the time of the Hindu epics, and as such predate the Puranas, which also quote from them extensively. Toward the end of the tenth century, a series of invasions by Muslim warlords and empire builders provoked a backlash among the north Indian brahmin orthodoxy against all that was not "Vedic" in Hindu theory and practice. Much of the ideology of this project of hieratic entrenchment may be found in commentaries written on the Smritis during this period.

Most interesting is the position taken by Lakshmidhara, a mid-twelfth-century royal minister, judge, and legal scholar from the kingdom of Kanauj in India's Gangetic heartland, and author of the massive *Kritya-kalpataru* ("The Wish-Fulfilling Tree of Sacred Duty"). A "great encyclopedic construction of the 'Hindu way of life,'" this digest of Hindu law was compiled precisely, according to Sheldon Pollack, as an orthodox Hindu reaction to repeated Islamic encroachments into the Indian subcontinent. Lakshmidhara's is mainly an *argumentum ex silentio*. In his six chapters on Yoga, he quotes over five hundred verses from the *Bhagavad* †

*Gita*, the *Mahabharata*'s twelfth book, six Puranas, and several other works, but only two verses from the *Yoga* † *Sutra*. While he does acknowledge Patanjali as the source for his definition of Yoga, he nonetheless attributes the eight-part practice to the *Mahabharata*. † In fact, a verse from the *Mahabharata*'s twelfth book harks back to Vedic sages who "described Yoga as eightfold," and long passages from the same book encapsulate many of the basic tenets of Yoga philosophy, obviating the need for Lakshmidhara to refer to Patanjali as his standard reference.

In addition to scripture, orthodox commentators like Lakshmidhara also favored works attributed to Yajnavalkya over Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra* as their authorized † source on Yoga. Several works, including the "Tradition of Yogi Yajnavalkya" and "Yajnavalkya's Yoga," were attributed to this latter figure who, because his † was the same name as that of an Upanishadic sage, was considered to be an ancient authority. For Advaita Vedanta commentators, the *Yoga Vasistha*, a tenth- to † thirteenth-century work attributed to the Vedic sage Vasistha, became the reference of choice in matters of Yoga philosophy. Others, as we have seen, favored the divine Hiranyagarbha as their default founder of the Yoga system. Without such *titres de noblesse*, Patanjali and his work were discredited as inauthentic. On the basis of these data, we can see that by the twelfth century, Patanjali's system had been caught in a pincer movement of sorts, rejected by orthodox brahmins for being beyond the pale of the Vedas and by the burgeon-

ing ranks of Hindu devotees of gods like Krishna, Vishnu, and Shiva for being nondevotional.

In comparing the commentarial tradition to the process of judicial review in chapter 1, I suggested that through changing philosophical and real-world contexts, gradual shifts in the perceived meanings of concepts could gradually alter the global understanding of a philosophical work, sometimes beyond recognition. This was the effect that Vijñanabhikṣu's theistic reading of Ishvara had on *Yoga Sutra* commentary. Following him, there would be very few original commentaries on Patanjali's work, and what rare commentaries there were tended only to accentuate the trend he had initiated, further overwriting its Sāṃkhya-Yoga material with a Vedānta-based devotional gloss. When devotion to an omnipotent personal God or Goddess was sufficient to free humans from suffering existence, what need was there for Yoga practice, for the difficult task of clarifying the mind-stuff and meditating on the individual Puruṣa's intrinsic isolation from Prakṛiti? By Vijñanabhikṣu's time, Vedānta-based Hindu devotion had rendered Yoga philosophy irrelevant. This is not to say that Vijñanabhikṣu single-handedly brought about the death of Yoga philosophy, which had been in decline for several centuries before him: he simply made it official. For the following three centuries, nearly all of India would be a Yoga desert. †